

'Who looks after your wants there?'

'An old Mrs Archer comes in every morning to 'do for me,' as it's called.'

'Do you think she would remember when the pistol was there last?'

'I don't know. She might. But I don't fancy conscientious dusting is her strong point.'

'It comes to this—that almost anyone might have taken that pistol?'

'It seems so—yes.'

The door opened and Dr Haydock came in with Anne Protheroe.

She started at seeing Lawrence. He, on his part, made a tentative step towards her.

'Forgive me, Anne,' he said. 'It was abominable of me to think what I did.'

'I—' she faltered, then looked appealingly at Colonel Melchett. 'It is true, what Dr Haydock told me?'

'That Mr Redding is cleared of suspicion? Yes. And now what about this story of yours, Mrs Protheroe? Eh, what about it?'

She smiled rather shamefacedly.

'I suppose you think it dreadful of me?'

'Well, shall we say—very foolish? But that's all over. What I want now, Mrs Protheroe, is the truth—the absolute truth.'

She nodded gravely.

'I will tell you. I suppose you know about—about everything?'

'Yes.'

'I was to meet Lawrence—Mr Redding—that evening at the studio. At a quarter past six. My husband and I drove into the village together. I had some shopping to do. As we parted he mentioned casually that he was going to see the Vicar. I couldn't get word to Lawrence, and I was rather uneasy. I—well, it was awkward meeting him in the Vicarage garden while my husband was at the Vicarage.'

Her cheeks burned as she said this. It was not a pleasant moment for her.

'I reflected that perhaps my husband would not stay very long. To find this out, I came along the back lane and into the garden. I hoped no one would see me, but of course old Miss Marple had to be in her garden! She stopped me and we said a few words, and I explained I was going to call for my husband. I felt I had to say something. I don't know whether she believed me or not. She looked rather—funny.'

'When I left her, I went straight across to the Vicarage and round the corner of the house to the study window. I crept up to it very softly expecting to hear the sound of voices. But to my surprise there were none. I just glanced in, saw the room was empty, and hurried across the lawn and down to the studio where Lawrence joined me almost at once.'

'You say the room was empty, Mrs Protheroe?'

'Yes; my husband was not there.'

'Extraordinary.'

'You mean, M'am, that you didn't see him?' said the Inspector.

'No, I didn't see him.'

Inspector Slack whispered to the Chief Constable, who nodded his head.

'Do you mind, Mrs Protheroe, just showing us exactly what you did?'

'Not at all.'

She rose; Inspector Slack pushed open the window for her, and she stepped out on the terrace and round the house to the left.

Inspector Slack beckoned me imperiously to go and sit at the writing table. Somehow I didn't much like doing it. It gave me an uncomfortable feeling.

But of course I complied.

Presently I heard footsteps outside; they paused for a minute, then retreated. Inspector Slack indicated to me that I could return to the other side of the room. Mrs Protheroe re-entered through the window.

'Is that exactly how it was?' asked Colonel Melchett.

'I think exactly.'

'Then can you tell us, Mrs Protheroe, just exactly where the Vicar was in the room when you looked in?' asked Inspector Slack.

'The Vicar? I—no, I'm afraid I can't. I didn't see him.'

Inspector Slack nodded.

'That's how you didn't see your husband. He was round the corner of the writing desk.'

'Oh!' she paused. Suddenly her eyes grew round with horror. 'It wasn't there that—that—'

'Yes, Mrs Protheroe. It was while he was sitting there.'

'Oh!' she shivered.

He went on with his questions.

'Did you know, Mrs Protheroe, that Mr Redding had a pistol?'

'Yes. He told me so once.'

'Did you ever have that pistol in your possession?'

She shook her head.

'No.'

'Did you know where he kept it?'

'I'm not sure. I think—yes, I think I've seen it on a shelf in his cottage.'

Didn't you keep it there, Lawrence?'

'When was the last time you were at the cottage, Mrs Protheroe?'

'Oh! about three weeks ago. My husband and I had tea there with him.'

'And you have not been there since?'

'No. I never went there. You see, it would probably cause a lot of talk in the village.'

'Doubtless,' said Colonel Melchett drily. 'Where were you in the habit of seeing Mr Redding, if I may ask?'

She blushed.

'He used to come up to the Hall. He was painting Lettice. We—we often met in the woods afterwards.'

Colonel Melchett nodded.

'Isn't that enough?' Her voice was suddenly broken. 'It's so awful—having to tell you all these things. And—and there wasn't anything wrong about it. There wasn't—indeed, there wasn't. We were just friends. We—we couldn't help caring for each other.'

She looked pleadingly at Dr Haydock, and that soft-hearted man stepped forward.

'I really think, Melchett,' he said, 'that Mrs Protheroe has had enough. She's had a great shock—in more ways than one.'

The Chief Constable nodded.

'There is really nothing more I want to ask you, Mrs Protheroe,' he said.

'Thank you for answering my questions so frankly.'

'Then—then I may go?'

He bowed his head in assent, but I noticed him make an almost imperceptible sign to Slack, which that worthy answered with a nod of understanding. Anne Protheroe was not yet completely cleared of suspicion. The evidence of the note was too strong.

walking—at last I couldn't bear it any longer. If Anne had done this ghastly thing, I was, at least, morally responsible. I went and gave myself up.'

There was a silence when he had finished. Then the Colonel said in a businesslike voice:

'I would like to ask just one or two questions. First, did you touch or move the body in any way?'

'No, I didn't touch it at all. One could see he was dead without touching him.'

'Did you notice a note lying on the blotter half concealed by his body?'

'No.'

'Did you interfere in any way with the clock?'

'I never touched the clock. I seem to remember a clock lying overturned on the table, but I never touched it.'

'Now as to this pistol of yours, when did you last see it?'

Lawrence Redding reflected.

'It's hard to say exactly.'

'Where do you keep it?'

'Oh! in a litter of odds and ends in the sitting room in my cottage. On one of the shelves of the bookcase.'

'You left it lying about carelessly?'

'Yes. I really didn't think about it. It was just there.'

'So that anyone who came to your cottage could have seen it?'

'Yes.'

'And you don't remember when you last saw it?'

Lawrence drew his brows together in a frown of recollection.

'I'm almost sure it was there the day before yesterday. I remember pushing it aside to get an old pipe. I think it was the day before yesterday—but it may have been the day before that.'

'Who has been to your cottage lately?'

'Oh! crowds of people. Someone is always drifting in and out. I had a sort of tea party the day before yesterday. Lettice Protheroe, Dennis, and all their crowd. And then one or other of the old Pussies comes in now and again.'

'Do you lock the cottage up when you go out?'

'No, why on earth should I? I've nothing to steal. And no one does lock his house up round here.'

'There's not much to tell. I—I met Mrs Protheroe that afternoon—'
He paused.

'We know all about that,' said Melchert. 'You may think that your feeling for Mrs Protheroe and hers for you was a dead secret, but in reality it was known and commented upon. In any case everything is bound to come out now.'

'Very well then. I expect you are right. I had promised the Vicar here' (he glanced at me) 'to—to go right away. I met Mrs Protheroe that evening in the studio at a quarter past six. I told her of what I had decided. She, too, agreed, that it was the only thing to do. We—we said good-bye to each other.'

'We left the studio, and almost at once Dr Stone joined us. Anne managed to seem marvellously natural. I couldn't do it. I went off with Stone to the Blue Boar and had a drink. Then I thought I'd go home, but, when I got to the corner of this road, I changed my mind and decided to come along and see the Vicar. I felt I wanted someone to talk to about the matter.'

'At the door, the maid told me the Vicar was out but would be in shortly, but that Colonel Protheroe was in the study waiting for him. Well, I didn't like to go away again—looked as though I were shirking meeting him. So I said I'd wait too, and I went into the study.'

He stopped.

'Well?' said Colonel Melchert.

'Protheroe was sitting at the writing table—just as you found him. I went up to him. I saw that he was dead. Then I looked down and saw the pistol lying on the floor beside him. I picked it up—and at once saw that it was my pistol!'

'That gave me a turn. My pistol! And then, straightway I leaped to one conclusion. Anne must have bagged my pistol some time or other—meaning it for herself if she couldn't bear things any longer. Perhaps she had had it with her today. After we parted in the village she must have come back here and—and—Oh! I suppose I was mad to think of it. But that's what I thought. I slipped the pistol in my pocket and came away. Just outside the Vicarage gate, I met the Vicar. He said something nice and normal about seeing Protheroe—suddenly I had a wild desire to laugh. His manner was so ordinary and everyday, and there was I all strung up. I remember shouting out something absurd and seeing his face change. I was nearly off my head, I believe. I went walking—

'Is your wife in?' asked Haydock. 'I think Mrs Protheroe would like to see her.'

'Yes,' I said, 'Griselda is in. You'll find her in the drawing room.'

She and Haydock left the room together, and Lawrence Redding with them.

Colonel Melchert had pursed up his lips and was playing with a paper knife. Slack was looking at the note. It was then that I mentioned Miss Marple's theory.

Slack looked closely at it.

'My word,' he said, 'I believe the old lady's right. Look here, sir, don't you see?—these figures are written in different ink. That date was written with a fountain pen or I'll eat my boots!'

We were all rather excited.

'You've examined the note for fingerprints, of course,' said the Chief Constable.

'What do you think, Colonel? No fingerprints on the note at all. Fingerprints on the pistol those of Mr Lawrence Redding. May have been some others once, before he went fooling round with it and carrying it around in his pocket, but there's nothing clear enough to get hold of now.'

'At first the case looked very black against Mrs Protheroe,' said the Colonel thoughtfully. 'Much blacker than against young Redding. There was that old woman Marple's evidence that she didn't have the pistol with her, but these elderly ladies are often mistaken.'

I was silent, but I did not agree with him. I was quite sure that Anne Protheroe had had no pistol with her, since Miss Marple had said so. Miss Marple is not the type of elderly lady who makes mistakes. She has got an uncanny knack of being always right.

'What did get me was that nobody heard the shot. If it was fired then—somebody *must* have heard it—wherever they thought it came from. Slack, you'd better have a word with the maid.'

Inspector Slack moved with alacrity towards the door.

'I shouldn't ask her if she heard a shot in the house,' I said. 'Because if you do, she'll deny it. Call it a shot in the wood. That's the only kind of shot she'll admit to hearing.'

'I know how to manage them,' said Inspector Slack, and disappeared.

‘Miss Marple says she heard a shot later,’ said Colonel Melchett thoughtfully. ‘We must see if she can fix the time at all precisely. Of course it may be a stray shot that had nothing to do with the case.’

‘It may be, of course,’ I agreed.

The Colonel took a turn or two up and down the room.

‘Do you know, Clement,’ he said suddenly, ‘I’ve a feeling that this is going to turn out a much more intricate and difficult business than any of us think. Dash it all, there’s something behind it.’ He snorted. ‘Something we don’t know about. We’re only beginning, Clement. Mark my words, we’re only beginning. All these things, the clock, the note, the pistol—they don’t make sense as they stand.’

I shook my head. They certainly didn’t.

‘But I’m going to get to the bottom of it. No calling in of Scotland Yard. Slack’s a smart man. He’s a very smart man. He’s a kind of ferret. He’ll nose his way through to the truth. He’s done several very good things already and this case will be his *chef d’œuvre*. Some men would call in Scotland Yard. I shan’t. We’ll get to the bottom of this here in Downshire.’

‘I hope so, I’m sure,’ I said.

I tried to make my voice enthusiastic, but I had already taken such a dislike to Inspector Slack that the prospect of his success failed to appeal to me. A successful Slack would, I thought, be even more odious than a baffled one.

‘Who has the house next door?’ asked the Colonel suddenly.

‘You mean at the end of the road? Mrs Price Ridley.’

‘We’ll go along to her after Slack has finished with your maid. She might just possibly have heard something. She isn’t deaf or anything, is she?’

‘I should say her hearing was remarkably keen. I’m going by the amount of scandal she has started by “just happening to overhear accidentally.”’

‘That’s the kind of woman we want. Oh! here’s Slack.’

The Inspector had the air of one emerging from a severe tussle. He looked hot.

‘Phew!’ he said. ‘That’s a tartar you’ve got, sir.’

‘Mary is essentially a girl of strong character,’ I replied.

‘Doesn’t like the police,’ he said. ‘I cautioned her—did what I could to put the fear of the Law into her, but no good. She stood right up to me.’

‘Spirted,’ I said, feeling more kindly towards Mary.

Chapter 12

I was summoned to the study when Lawrence Redding arrived. He looked haggard, and, I thought, suspicious. Colonel Melchett greeted him with something approaching cordiality.

‘We want to ask you a few questions—here, on the spot,’ he said.

Lawrence sneered slightly.

‘Isn’t that a French idea? Reconstruction of the crime?’

‘My dear boy,’ said Colonel Melchett. ‘Don’t take that tone with us. Are you aware that someone else has also confessed to committing the crime which you pretend to have committed?’

The effect of these words on Lawrence was painful and immediate.

‘Someone else?’ he stammered. ‘Who—who?’

‘Mrs Protheroe,’ said Colonel Melchett, watching him.

‘Absurd. She never did it. She couldn’t have. It’s impossible.’

Melchett interrupted him.

‘Strangely enough, we did not believe her story. Neither, I may say, do we believe yours. Dr Haydock says positively that the murder could not have been committed at the time you say it was.’

‘Dr Haydock says that?’

‘Yes; so, you see, you are cleared whether you like it or not. And now we want you to help us, to tell us exactly what occurred.’

Lawrence still hesitated.

‘You’re not deceiving me about—about Mrs Protheroe? You really don’t suspect her?’

‘On my word of honour,’ said Colonel Melchett.

Lawrence drew a deep breath.

‘I’ve been a fool,’ he said. ‘An absolute fool. How I could have thought for one minute that she did it—’

‘Suppose you tell us all about it?’ suggested the Chief Constable.

'But I pinned her down all right. She heard one shot—and one shot only. And it was a good long time after Colonel Protheroe came. I couldn't get her to name a time, but we fixed it at last by means of the fish. The fish was late, and she blew the boy up when he came, and he said it was barely half past six anyway, and it was just after that she heard the shot. Of course, that's not accurate, so to speak, but it gives us an idea.'

'H'm,' said Melchett.

'I don't think Mrs Protheroe's in this after all,' said Slack, with a note of regret in his voice. 'She wouldn't have had time, to begin with, and then women never like fiddling about with firearms. Arsenic's more in their line. No, I don't think she did it. It's a pity!'

He sighed.

Melchett explained that he was going round to Mrs Price Ridley's, and Slack approved.

'May I come with you?' I asked. 'I'm getting interested.'

I was given permission and we set forth. A loud 'Hi' greeted us as we emerged from the Vicarage gate, and my nephew, Dennis, came running up the road from the village to join us.

'Look here,' he said to the Inspector. 'What about that footprint I told you about?'

'Gardener's,' said Inspector Slack laconically.

'You don't think it might be someone else wearing the gardener's boots?'

'No, I don't,' said Inspector Slack in a discouraging way.

It would take more than that to discourage Dennis, however.

He held out a couple of burnt matches.

'I found these by the Vicarage gate.'

'Thank you,' said Slack and put them in his pocket.

Matters appeared now to have reached a deadlock.

'You're not arresting Uncle Len, are you?' inquired Dennis facetiously.

'Why should I?' inquired Slack.

'There's a lot of evidence against him,' declared Dennis. 'You ask Mary. Only the day before the murder he was wishing Colonel Protheroe out of the world. Weren't you, Uncle Len?'

'Et—' I began.

Inspector Slack turned a slow, suspicious stare upon me, and I felt hot all over. Dennis is exceedingly tiresome. He ought to realize that a policeman seldom has a sense of humour.

'Don't be absurd, Dennis,' I said irritably.

The innocent child opened his eyes in a stare of surprise.

'I say, it's only a joke,' he said. 'Uncle Len just said that anyone who murdered Colonel Protheroe would be doing the world a service.'

'Ah!' said Inspector Slack, 'that explains something the maid said.'

Servants very seldom have any sense of humour either. I cursed Dennis heartily in my mind for bringing the matter up. That and the clock together will make the Inspector suspicious of me for life.

'Come on, Clement,' said Colonel Melchett.

'Where are you going? Can I come too?' asked Dennis.

'No, you can't,' I snapped.

We left him looking after us with a hurt expression. We went up to the neat front door of Mrs Price Ridley's house, and the Inspector knocked and rang in what I can only describe as an official manner.

A pretty parlour maid answered the bell.

'Mrs Price Ridley in?' inquired Melchett.

'No, sir.' The maid paused and added, 'She's just gone down to the police station.'

This was a totally unexpected development. As we retraced our steps, Melchett caught me by the arm and murmured:

'If she's gone to confess to the crime too, I really shall go off my head.'

I thought she was probably persuading herself of the fact rather than actually remembering it, but she had just contributed such a valuable new outlook to the problem that I felt highly respectful towards her.

She rose, murmuring that she must really get back—it had been so tempting just to run over and discuss the case with dear Griselda. I escorted her to the boundary wall and the back gate, and returned to find Griselda wrapped in thought.

'Still puzzling over that note?' I asked.

'No.'

She gave a sudden shiver and shook her shoulders impatiently.

'Len, I've been thinking. How badly someone must have hated Anne Protheroe.'

'Hated her?'

'Yes. Don't you see? There's no real evidence against Lawrence—all the evidence against him is what you might call accidental. He just happens to take it into his head to come here. If he hadn't—well, no one would have thought of connecting him with the crime. But Anne is different. Suppose someone knew that she was here at exactly 6.20—the clock and the time on the letter—everything pointing to her. I don't think it was only because of an alibi it was moved to that exact time—I think there was more in it than that—a direct attempt to fasten the business on her. If it hadn't been for Miss Marple saying she hadn't got the pistol with her, and noticing that she was only a moment before going down to the studio—Yes, if it hadn't been for that...' She shivered again. 'Len—I feel that someone hated Anne Protheroe very much. I—I don't like it.'

'If only,' I said, 'the letter hadn't been dated—'

Miss Marple nodded her head.

'Exactly,' she said. 'If it *hadn't* been dated!'

I cast my mind back, trying to recall that sheet of notepaper and the blurred scrawl, and at the top that neatly printed 6.20. Surely these figures were on a different scale to the rest of the letter.

I gave a gasp.

'Supposing,' I said, 'it wasn't dated. Supposing that round about 6.30 Colonel Protheroe got impatient and sat down to say he couldn't wait any longer. And as he was sitting there writing, someone came in through the window—'

'Or through the door,' suggested Griselda.

'He'd hear the door and look up.'

'Colonel Protheroe was rather deaf, you remember,' said Miss Marple.

'Yes, that's true. He wouldn't hear it. Whichever way the murderer came, he stole up behind the Colonel and shot him. Then he saw the note and the clock and the idea came to him. He put 6.20 at the top of the letter and he altered the clock to 6.22. It was a clever idea. It gave him, or so he would think, a perfect alibi.'

'And what we want to find,' said Griselda, 'is someone who has a cast iron alibi for 6.20, but no alibi at all for—well, that isn't so easy. One can't fix the time.'

'We can fix it within very narrow limits,' I said. 'Haydock places 6.30 as the outside limit of time. I suppose one could perhaps shift it to 6.35, from the reasoning we have just been following out; it seems clear that Protheroe would not have got impatient before 6.30. I think we can say we do know pretty well.'

'Then that shot I heard—yes, I suppose it is quite possible. And I thought nothing about it—nothing at all. Most vexing. And yet, now I try to recollect, it does seem to me that it was different from the usual sort of shot one hears. Yes, there was a difference.'

'Louder?' I suggested.

No, Miss Marple didn't think it had been louder. In fact, she found it hard to say in what way it had been different, but she still insisted that it was.

Chapter 13

I hardly thought it likely that Mrs Price Ridley had anything so dramatic in view, but I did wonder what had taken her to the police station. Had she really got evidence of importance, or that she thought of importance, to offer? At any rate we should soon know.

We found Mrs Price Ridley talking at a high rate of speed to a somewhat bewildered looking police constable. That she was extremely indignant I knew from the way the bow in her hat was trembling. Mrs Price Ridley wears what, I believe, are known as 'Hats for Matrons'—they make a specialty of them in our adjacent town of Much Benham. They perch easily on a superstructure of hair and are somewhat overweighted with large bows of ribbon. Griselda is always threatening to get a Matron's hat.

Mrs Price Ridley paused in her flow of words upon our entrance.

'Mrs Price Ridley?' inquired Colonel Melchett, lifting his hat.

'Let me introduce Colonel Melchett to you, Mrs Price Ridley,' I said. 'Colonel Melchett is our Chief Constable.'

Mrs Price Ridley looked at me coldly, but produced the semblance of a gracious smile for the Colonel.

'We've just been round to your house, Mrs Price Ridley,' explained the Colonel, 'and heard you had come down here.'

Mrs Price Ridley thawed altogether.

'Ah!' she said. 'I'm glad *some* notice is being taken of the occurrence. Disgraceful, I call it. Simply disgraceful.'

There is no doubt that murder is disgraceful, but it is not the word I should use to describe it myself. It surprised Melchett too, I could see.

'Have you any light to throw upon the matter?' he asked.

'That's your business. It's the business of the police. What do we pay rates and taxes for, I should like to know?'

One wonders how many times that query is uttered in a year!

'We're doing our best, Mrs Price Ridley,' said the Chief Constable.

'But the man here hadn't even heard of it till I told him about it!' cried the lady.

We all looked at the constable.

'Lady been rung up on the telephone,' he said. 'Annoyed. Matter of obscene language, I understand.'

'Oh! I see.' The Colonel's brow cleared. 'We've been talking at cross purposes. You came down here to make a complaint, did you?'

Melchert is a wise man. He knows that, when it is a question of an irate middle-aged lady, there is only one thing to be done—to listen to her. When she has said all that she wants to say, there is a chance that she will listen to you.

Mrs Price Ridley surged into speech.

'Such disgraceful occurrences ought to be prevented. They ought not to occur. To be rung up in one's own house and insulted—yes, insulted. I'm not accustomed to such things happening. Ever since the War there has been a loosening of moral fibre. Nobody minds what they say, and as to the clothes they wear—'

'Quite,' said Colonel Melchert hastily. 'What happened exactly?'

Mrs Price Ridley took breath and started again.

'I was rung up—'

'When?'

'Yesterday afternoon—evening to be exact. About half past six. I went to the telephone, suspecting nothing. Immediately I was foully attacked, threatened—'

'What actually was said?'

Mrs Price Ridley got slightly pink.

'That I decline to state.'

'Obscene language,' murmured the Constable in a ruminative bass.

'Was bad language used?' asked Colonel Melchert.

'It depends on what you call bad language.'

'Could you understand it?' I asked.

'Of course I could understand it.'

'Then it couldn't have been bad language,' I said.

Mrs Price Ridley looked at me suspiciously.

Rather to my surprise Griselda coloured up. Something very like tears started into her eyes. She clenched both her small hands.

'Oh!' she cried indignantly. 'People are hateful—hateful. The things they say! The beastly things they say!'

I looked at her curiously. It is very unlike Griselda to be so upset. She noticed my glance and tried to smile.

'Don't look at me as though I were an interesting specimen you didn't understand, Len. Don't let's get heated and wander from the point. I don't believe that it was Lawrence or Anne, and Lettice is out of the question. There must be some clue or other that would help us.'

'There is the note, of course,' said Miss Marple. 'You will remember my saying this morning that that struck me as exceedingly peculiar.'

'It seems to fix the time of his death with remarkable accuracy,' I said. 'And yet, is that possible? Mrs Protheroe would only have just left the study. She would hardly have had time to reach the studio. The only way in which I can account for it is that he consulted his own watch and that his watch was slow. That seems to me a feasible solution.'

'I have another idea,' said Griselda. 'Suppose, Len, that the clock had already been put back—no, that comes to the same thing—how stupid of me!'

'It hadn't been altered when I left,' I said. 'I remember comparing it with my watch. Still, as you say, that has no bearing on the present matter.'

'What do you think, Miss Marple?' asked Griselda.

The old lady shook her head.

'My dear, I confess I wasn't thinking about it from that point of view at all. What strikes me as so curious, and has done from the first, is the subject matter of that letter.'

'I don't see that,' I said. 'Colonel Protheroe merely wrote that he couldn't wait any longer—'

'*At twenty minutes past six?*' said Miss Marple. 'Your maid, Mary, had already told him that you wouldn't be in till half past six at the earliest, and he had appeared to be quite willing to wait until then. And yet, at twenty past six, he sits down and says he "can't wait any longer."'

I stared at the old lady, feeling an increased respect for her mental powers. Her keen wits had seen what we had failed to perceive. It *was* an odd thing—a very odd thing.